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COMPETING FOOTSTEPS
Far left, a Chinese Xiaokang village near the border with Arunachal Pradesh; left, an Indian C130J transport aircraft takes off from the Daulat Beg Oldie airfield

ORDERS | *China's strategic infrastructure drive and India's response to it*

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- Advanced airfields at Daulat Beg Oldie, Fukche, Nyoma, Tuting, Mechuka, Along, Ziro, Pasighat, Vijaynagar
- New roads include 1,800-km-long Frontier Highway in Arunachal, Sela Tunnel road project connecting Tawang with Guwahati, Balipara-Charduar-Tawang (BCT) road, Ladakh's Chisumle-Demchok Road
- New railways: 200 km Bhalukpong-Tawang line, 87 km Silapathar (Assam)-Along line, 217 km Rupai (Assam)-Pasighat line
- Vibrant Villages programme to develop 2,967 border villages in Arunachal, Sikkim, Uttarakhand, Himachal, Ladakh

317 km Balipara-Charduar-Tawang (BCT) road. When completed, both will ensure vital all-year mobility.

In Ladakh, an under-construction road will provide alternative connectivity to western Ladakh and the Zanskar Valley from the Manali axis in Himachal Pradesh. Two-thirds of the work on the 298-km-long double-lane road has been completed. The strategically crucial Darbuk-Shyok-Daulat Beg Oldie (DS-DBO) road in eastern Ladakh, which provides access to high-altitude airfields and military posts near the LAC, is also being upgraded. Newer roads, such as Ladakh's Chisumle-Demchok Road, have improved the Indian military's battle readiness. The 52 km road connects towns in the Chumar sector in eastern Ladakh with Leh and the Nyoma and Karu military stations.

Indian Railways is building three strategic lines in the Northeast to enable the Indian army to mobilise fast: a 200 km line between Bhalukpong and Tawang (Arunachal Pradesh), an 87 km line between Silapathar (Assam) and Along via Bame (Arunachal) and a 217 km line between Rupai (Assam) and Pasighat (Arunachal). A 125 km line between Lakhimpur (Assam) and Ziro is planned. Up north, work is underway on the 489 km long high-elevation Bhanupli (Punjab)-Leh rail line.

The IAF now has 25 airfields from where they can launch operations into China and is fast upgrading its Advanced Landing Grounds (ALGs) near the border. All IAF airfields are getting hardened aircraft and equipment shelters. In eastern Ladakh, airfields are being made/ upgraded in DBO, Fukche and Nyoma. The Nyoma air base, barely 50 km from the LAC, is being developed to operate fighter aircraft, new radars and upgraded military drones. Nyoma, the world's highest airfield at 13,700 ft, will be the third air base in Ladakh to support fighter aircraft operations after Leh and Thoise. In Arunachal, three new airfields have been constructed in Tezu, Pasighat and Holongi, while the Ziro airfield is now upgraded. They all have dual-use potential.

India's answer to China's Xiaokang villages has been the Vibrant Villages Programme, inaugurated by Union home minister Amit Shah in April 2023 in Arunachal Pradesh's Kibithu. The programme has identified 2,967 villages in 46 blocks of 19 districts bordering China in Arunachal, Sikkim, Uttarakhand, Himachal and the Union Territory of Ladakh. The Union government will contribute Rs 4,800 crore towards it from FY23 to FY26, including Rs 2,500 crore for road connectivity to these border villages.

One difference between Chinese and Indian border villages is that while the Xiaokang dual-use villages are built from scratch, typically in remote areas where there was no habitation, the Indian programme is about constructing modern infrastructure in villages existing in border areas. Bishan Singh Chuphal, five-time MLA from border district of Pithoragarh in Uttarakhand, explains that these areas have in recent decades seen considerable out-migration due to poor transport/ communication facilities and livelihood opportunities. "The government believes that the project will help improve the standard of living and encourage villagers to stay on," says Chuphal. One thrust area is the promotion of tourism—adventure tourism, construction of homestays and promotion of festivals and fairs. The underlying goal of these villages is to strengthen security of border areas by having loyal citizens keep a watch on Chinese activities. ■